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Daniel Kokan under supervision of Judith Jayasuriya has written this case solely for the Asper Business Case Competition (ABCC) 2026. This case is presented with the support of the Stu Clark Graduate School. The author has no intention to comment on or evaluate the handling of managerial decisions within Jazz Winnipeg. Photocopying transmitting, distributing or reproduction this case in any form or by any means is strictly prohibited.

Jazz Winnipeg at a Crossroads: Accessibility, Culture, and Viability in the Changing Entertainment Industry

Introduction

On a late afternoon in early spring, Angela Heck, Jazz Winnipeg's Executive Director stood at the window of her office in downtown Winnipeg. The streets were quiet now, but she was picturing Old Market Square a few months from this moment: Musicians on stage, volunteers in bright shirts, crowds gathered with drinks in hand, the city alive with the sound of jazz – a familiar refrain in the rhythm of Winnipeg's summer.

For nearly 35 years, Jazz Winnipeg had been a constant in the cultural life of the city. Built on its commitment to accessibility, community, and the celebration of jazz in all forms, the organization had become known for its high-quality, free programming in the heart of downtown. A rarity in the entertainment landscape, Jazz Winnipeg wasn't just about a music festival; it created a shared experience and a community around jazz.

However, reviewing the latest figures, it was clear that goodwill alone couldn't sustain the organization. Artist fees were increasing faster than revenues, and audiences were changing how and where they engaged with music. Superstar performers commanded prices much higher than mid-sized festivals could afford, and while raising ticket prices was an avenue for some to close that gap, Jazz Winnipeg's commitment to accessibility was paramount. Despite stable attendance and strong community support, Jazz Winnipeg was losing approximately $50,000 annually, threatening long-term viability.

Leaning operations and volunteer involvement could only take the organization so far. Angela knew the question was no longer how to preserve exactly what Jazz Winnipeg was, but how to evolve it without losing what made it special. Should she double down on the festival experience? Invest in digital platforms? Reimagine year-round programming? Add services (like a booking agency?) Or rethink what accessibility means in the music industry?

Jazz Winnipeg's Identity

Jazz Winnipeg is a nonprofit arts organization rooted in a clear and timeless purpose: to make Jazz accessible, inclusive, and visible as a vital part of cultural life in Winnipeg. Founded more than three decades ago, the organization started at a time when live music was primarily experienced in physical venues and through shared, in-person events. Over time, Jazz Winnipeg evolved into one of the city's most recognized cultural institutions, defined not only by the music it presents, but by how and where it is presented.

> *Our mandate includes bolstering local performers, providing a pathway to development for artists and audiences to experience jazz, and expose Manitobans to top-tier performers from around the globe.*
>
> *Angela Heck, Executive Director, Jazz Winnipeg*

At its core, Jazz Winnipeg's identity is committed to accessibility. This includes physical accessibility for people with disabilities and members of the deaf community, economic accessibility through free public programming, and cultural accessibility that welcomes both long-time jazz aficionados and newcomers to the genre. This is most visible in the organization's

downtown presence. The annual Winnipeg Jazz Festival free performances at Old Market Square have become a signature feature, transforming a public space into a shared gathering place, and reinforcing Jazz Winnipeg's role as a cultural anchor, rather than exclusively as an entertainment provider.

Jazz Winnipeg's mission also reflects a strong commitment to community and artist development. The organization prioritizes opportunities for local and Canadian artists, often pairing emerging musicians with more established acts, creating platforms for artists to reach new audiences. Beyond the festival itself, Jazz Winnipeg has expanded into year-round programming, including recurring concert series and partnerships with local venues designed to sustain engagement beyond the festival itself. These initiatives reflect the understanding that jazz is more than just a musical experience; it's a living, evolving art form embedded in the city's culture.

Critically, as a non-profit cultural charity, Jazz Winnipeg's success is not defined solely in commercial terms. It emphasizes impact over profit: audience reach, community connection, downtown activation, and cultural vibrancy are equal to financial performance. At the same time, these values introduce constraints. A strong commitment to free access limits flexibility in pricing. The historical decision to use downtown locations promoted walkability and sustainability but narrowed options for venues so the organization is now also using the newly built concert hall at the University of Manitoba. A mission centred on community puts boundaries on how aggressively the organization can pursue commercial opportunities. What has been Jazz Winnipeg's greatest strength historically – its clarity of purpose and cultural mission – must set the boundaries for change.

The organization also encounters a recurring question: *What is Jazz?* Educating audiences remains a priority for an artform that encompasses many musical styles, from traditional New Orleans jazz to hip hop and other creative music.

As the organization looks toward its future, the challenge is not whether Jazz Winnipeg should remain mission-driven, but how that mission can be delivered in a very different economic and technological environment. Jazz Winnipeg's values guide its aspirations but also raise questions about what evolution is possible and practical without compromising the organization's identity.

What was once a steady groove now risked slipping out of time with the rapidly changing industry.

Festivals in Today's Music Industry

Over the past twenty years, the live music industry has undergone a fundamental shift. Changes in how audiences discover, consume, and value music have altered the economics of live performances, placing increased pressure on organizations that rely on traditional festival models. These pressures are especially taxing for mid-sized, nonprofit festivals, where scale and pricing power are limited. Manitoba has many such festivals in addition to Jazz Winnipeg's – Fringe, Folkfest, and Countryfest, each of which have carved out their own space in the annual calendar and competes for audiences, sponsors, and public attention.

One of the most visible changes has been the rise of "superstar economics". A small number of globally recognized artists now command outsized attention and fees, driven by social media amplification, streaming platforms, and a winner-take-most entertainment environment. Audiences increasingly concentrate their entertainment spending on marquee, once-in-a-lifetime experiences, pushing artist fees to levels incompatible with most nonprofit festivals.

Artists who once represented attainable marquee programming have become prohibitively expensive. Performers such as Herbie Hancock now command fees exceeding $200,000, while artists like Robert Plant, once accessible at $100 per ticket, now require prices closer to $500 to break even. These dynamics have hollowed out the middle of the market, leaving regional festivals with a dilemma: marquee artists can attract attention and revenue, but only by accepting significant financial risk and reduced accessibility.

Festivals also face rising costs beyond artist fees. Production expenses, including staging, sound, lighting, security, and insurance have increased steadily. Public safety requirements and infrastructure needs have become more complex, particularly for outdoor events in urban spaces. These costs are relatively fixed, which is constraining when revenues fall short of targets or attendance is disrupted by weather-related factors – like a prairie thunderstorm rolling in.

At the same time, consumption of music has changed more broadly. Digital platforms have made recorded music more accessible than ever, reducing the barrier to entry for listeners while also diminishing the role of live performances as a means of music discovery. While live events are still culturally significant, they increasingly compete with a wide range of entertainment options, both digital and experiential. Many consumers, especially younger demographics, see live music as a selective, curated choice rather than a casual leisure activity.

Lastly, from a nonprofit perspective, these challenges are compounded by additional funding constraints. Government grants and public funding often come with specific mandates or requirements, such as supporting domestic talent or community accessibility, which may limit flexibility in programming. Sponsorship dollars have become more competitive as brands look for a return on their investment, favoring events with large, targeted audiences. Philanthropic funding is potentially more flexible but takes substantial commitment to build in terms of relationship building and curation.

All together, these shifts have made festivals more fragile. Balancing free and ticketed programming, multiple revenue streams, and adapting to shifting consumer expectations leaves little room for error.

Current Business and Revenue Model

Jazz Winnipeg's business model reflects its mission-driven priorities and the structural realities of nonprofit arts organizations. Unlike commercial promoters, the organization doesn't rely primarily on ticket sales to fund activities. Instead, it sustains operations through a mix of earned revenue, external funding, and in-kind support that covers both festival-related and year-round costs (see Appendix A). There is significant room for growth in philanthropic donations.

A significant portion of Jazz Winnipeg's earned revenue is generated during their annual festival, particularly through on-site beverage sales. This model is increasingly challenged by declining alcohol consumption among younger demographics, requiring greater attendance volumes to sustain revenue. Free outdoor programming in downtown Winnipeg draws large audiences, creating the

volume necessary to support a beer tent model that has historically served as a critical revenue source.

Ticketed performances offer another stream of earned revenue, through indoor concerts and certain festival events. These performances feature mid-tier or emerging artists whose fees are more manageable. However, ticket revenue alone rarely covers the full cost of presenting higher-profile acts. As a result, ticketed programming is a small part of a broader portfolio of revenue.

Sponsorship is a second major pillar of Jazz Winnipeg's funding model. Corporate partners support the festival and year-round programming in exchange for brand visibility, association with community and cultural vibrancy, and access to large audiences. However, sponsorship revenue is subject to marketing trends and often requires demonstrated audience reach to sustain. As more organizations compete for corporate sponsorship, Jazz Winnipeg faces increasing pressure to deliver value to their partners. While title sponsorship, such as TD bank's recent role as presenting sponsor, can provide meaningful support, it is inherently finite and does not fully mitigate this pressure. Further, category exclusivity of some sponsorships limits the pool of sponsors the organization can approach, increasing reliance on a smaller set of sponsors. Sponsorship success is closely tied to audience reach and visibility, reinforcing Jazz Winnipeg's reliance on large free crowds.

On the cost side, Jazz Winnipeg has a combination of fixed and variable expenses that persist throughout the year. Artist fees and production costs are the largest variable expense and are closely tied to decisions around programming. However, administrative costs, marketing, planning, and relationship management are year-round, regardless of the scale of production, which means the organization always has an underlying base of expenses.

The risks inherent in this model became particularly visible in 2019, when Jazz Winnipeg pursued a more ambitious programming strategy. That year, the organization booked five U.S.-based artists at fees ranging from $65,000 to $100,000, anticipating that increased ticket sales and audience interest would offset the higher costs. When box office sales fell short of those expectations, the festival recorded losses approaching $300,000. While the organization recovered, the experience had a lasting impact on leadership's approach to financial risk. It highlighted how quickly losses could

accumulate when programming decisions were misaligned with audience behavior and how limited the organization's ability was to absorb those kinds of setbacks.

Organization Structure, Staffing, and Execution

Jazz Winnipeg operates with a deliberately lean organizational structure designed to focus on programming while minimizing fixed costs. For most of the year, the organization is supported by a small core staff – their Artistic Director, and a seasonal marketing manager. Angela's role as Executive Director is fractional. The organization scales up substantially primarily through the efforts of more than 350 volunteers during the festival period as well as an additional 7 contractors plus technical teams. Execution is constrained by the breadth of roles a small team must take on throughout the year, shifting between administrative, creative, production, and relationship management depending on the time of year.

Jazz Winnipeg's programming is core to its operations. The Artistic Director has a deep understanding of the art of programming, as well as the marketplace. This includes keeping abreast of who is touring, what festivals are happening at any given time, and upcoming talent in the jazz scene. This centralized approach allows Jazz Winnipeg to remain agile and responsive to programming and touring opportunities, but it concentrates the decision-making and institutional knowledge in one individual. Jazz Winnipeg is exploring standing up a committee to support the Artistic Director on programming decisions.

Beyond artistic programming, much of the operational workload is handled through short-term contracts and seasonal hires, with the organization reaching a staff of ~10-12 people at peak times. As the festival approaches, Jazz Winnipeg ramps up capacity in marketing, box office operations, volunteer coordination and production support. While this model limits year-round overhead, it creates periods of intense concentrated work and makes institutional continuity difficult. Knowledge transfer between festival cycles relies heavily on documentation, informal processes, and the hope that key contractors and volunteers will return.

A defining feature of Jazz Winnipeg's execution model is its reliance on volunteers. Each year, 350

volunteers contribute thousands of hours of work to deliver the festival, supported by 25 experienced volunteer leads who oversee the different functional areas. The volunteer base is a significant organizational asset, allowing Jazz Winnipeg to deliver a large and complex event with limited paid staff. There are some considerations when working with a large body of volunteers: Availability, expertise, and succession are primarily uncontrollable, and the model assumes a level of goodwill that cannot be easily replicated or scaled in new initiatives.

Overall, the model is well-suited to delivering the high-quality annual festival the organization is known for, but there is not much room for experimentation, failure, or scale. Any strategic shift or new avenue for growth would require substantial financial investment, and consideration of how work is structured and resourced.

Audience, Accessibility, and the Experience Economy

Jazz Winnipeg's audience reflects the strength of its legacy and the challenges of sustaining relevance across generations. Survey data and attendance show a broad demographic range, from long-time patrons who see jazz as popular music, to a younger cohort that engages with the genre more selectively. Survey responses have historically suggested approximately 30% of attendees were between 18 and 30 years old, while another 50% were aged 50 and up. Engagement dropped noticeably among mid-career audiences, raising questions about audience continuity. This trend has changed in the last two years with more engagement spread evenly across all demographics. Most 18–30-year-olds engage with the festival at the free outdoor stage, while ticket-buyers skew older.

Accessibility has long been central to Jazz Winnipeg's approach to developing an audience. Free public programming lowers economic barriers and invites casual participants, allowing new fans to encounter jazz in informal, social settings. A downtown venue like Old Market Square functions as a performance space and gathering place, reinforcing the festival's role as a cultural experience rather than just transactional entertainment. This has enabled Jazz Winnipeg to reach its broad and diverse audience – including individuals who may not otherwise attend ticketed events.

The emphasis on free access complicates attempts to secure further financial engagement. While

large crowds attend free performances, converting that attendance into paid experiences, donations, or year-round participation at Jazz Winnipeg's events has proven difficult. Many attendees still view Jazz Winnipeg as a festival moment rather than an ongoing relationship. This limits opportunities to build patron value over time, particularly among younger audiences that prefer on-demand music consumption.

Audience expectations have also evolved in line with broader shifts toward an experience-based economy. Live music is increasingly valued not only for the performance itself, but also the surroundings – the atmosphere, social opportunities, visual appeal, and shareability. Festivals often offer highly curated experiences designed to be memorable, immersive, and easily communicated through social media. While the quality of the music is unquestioned, Jazz Winnipeg leadership questions whether the overall experience meets this new audience expectation.

Year-round programming is both an opportunity and challenge with this audience. Regular concert series, partnerships with local venues, and partnerships with other jazz organizations offer more intimate, predictable experiences that appeal to dedicated patrons. These events provide a path for deeper engagement and cultural continuity but have limited reach among younger demographics.

The shift in spending power to these younger generations further complicates the picture. Jazz Winnipeg must consider how future audiences will discover, value, and support live music. Younger patrons may be more open to non-traditional music experiences that blend digital engagement and may be less inclined to commit to traditional subscription or donor models.

Digital and Year-Round Music Engagement

As the demands of live performance have shifted, many organizations have explored both digital and year-round programming as ways to extend reach, deepen engagement, and diversify revenue. Any plans in this space must be carefully curated to align with Jazz Winnipeg's mission, capabilities, and resource constraints.

Jazz Winnipeg has already taken steps to move beyond a strictly festival-centric model. In addition to

the annual summer event, the organization supports recurring performances throughout the year including concert series that highlight local and Canadian artists. These supports are in partnership with other Jazz Organizations, such as the Izzy Asper Jazz Performance Series, The Winnipeg Jazz orchestra, as well as the Canadian Jazz Summit with the University of Manitoba's faculty of music.

Digital engagement is a particularly complex area. During the pandemic, Jazz Winnipeg – like many arts organizations – experimented with online content and virtual experiences as an alternative to in-person events. This helped maintain visibility and community connection when live performance was impossible. However, translating digital experiments into a long-term strategy remains an open question. Digital platforms can amplify artist exposure, reach audiences outside geographic boundaries, support education, or even generate new revenue streams. Each of these implies different investments, metrics for success, and new demands on operations.

For Jazz Winnipeg, the question is not just whether to pursue digital initiatives, but how to do it in a way that complements its core strengths. High quality digital content requires specialized production, distribution, and analytical skills – capabilities that do not naturally exist in a lean festival-oriented organization. Additionally, monetizing digital content in a crowded online environment is difficult, particularly for niche genres. However, digital platforms offer opportunities for accessibility for those unable to attend in person, extend the lifespan of performances by offering them for extended periods online, support artist development and promotion, and offer an additional channel to reach new potential patrons.

Partnerships represent a potential pathway for expanding capacity without bearing the full cost of innovation. Jazz Winnipeg has a history of collaborating with local organizations, educational institutions, and cultural partners. Extending this approach to digital production, content distribution, or cross-organizational programming could allow the organization to experiment with new models while minimizing risk. These partnerships would introduce complexity in governance, branding, and revenue sharing, which all require strategic planning and coordination.

Expanding into its own venue, such as a small performance space or jazz club has also been contemplated in the past. This would provide a way to extend engagement into year-round

programming, including curated live performances, workshops, and more community partnerships. It could further establish Jazz Winnipeg's continuous cultural presence, reinforce the brand, strengthen relationships with local artists, and create a consistent location for experimentation in both live and digital music engagement.

Together, digital engagement and year-round programming offer a set of strategic options rather than a concrete solution. Each option has different implications for staffing, level of investment, risk tolerance, and overall impact.

What has been tried?

Over the past several years, leadership has tested multiple approaches to balancing growth, accessibility, and financial sustainability in the face of significant external constraints.

Following the ambitious programming strategy in 2019, Jazz Winnipeg adopted a more conservative approach. Festival scope was reduced, including a contraction from ten days of programming to six. This lowered overall exposure and helped stabilize finances but was understood internally as a defensive measure rather than a long-term solution.

The organization also sought to optimize existing revenue streams. In recent years, Jazz Winnipeg expanded its licensed footprint at Old Market Square, effectively doubling beer sales expectations during the festival. While successful in the short term, this was inherently limited – beverage revenue remained dependent on weather, attendance, and regulatory conditions, and offered little opportunity for sustained transformation.

Jazz Winnipeg's foray into the digital space during the pandemic allowed the organization to catch its breath during a period of unprecedented disruption. However, as in-person events resumed, the digital initiatives remained largely experimental.

The organization has expanded its focus on year-round programming to deepen engagement beyond the festival. Regular concert series, including Sunday evening performances, were designed to create

consistent touchpoints with audiences and support local artists. These events appealed to established patrons and have shown encouraging trends that translate into significant audience growth. Younger demographics are also attracted by the opportunity to dress up – not just for the love of jazz, but for the whole experience – dressing up to take in some jazz at a club, and maybe have a couple of drinks.

Jazz Winnipeg also explored new forms of artistic and cultural engagement, securing federal funding to support international exposure for Canadian artists, including participation in cultural exchanges and industry events abroad. This aligned with the organization's cultural mandate and opened new opportunities for artists while also extending activities beyond just local in Winnipeg. Leadership saw these efforts as both promising and resource intensive.

Together, these efforts stabilized operations but also reinforced how difficult it was to generate sustainable growth without adding capacity or redefining the business model. All in all, Jazz Winnipeg understands its current capabilities and limits, and leadership is willing to take calculated risks or experiment with new models. Many potential avenues for growth had been tested in isolation, but none had yet resolved the tension between accessibility, scale, and financial sustainability.

Conclusion

As the afternoon light faded over downtown Winnipeg, Angela closed her laptop and looked once more toward Old Market Square. In a few months, the space would fill with music, volunteers, and audiences – a familiar rhythm in the life of Winnipeg. Yet beneath that familiarity was an uncomfortable truth: the festival’s outward success masked a growing fragility for the organization.

Jazz Winnipeg had survived by adapting before. It had weathered the changing economics of live presentation, the financial fallout of misjudged programming risks, and the sudden disappearance of live music during the pandemic. It had preserved public trust by staying true to its values – accessibility, community connection, and support for artists – even when doing so limited financial flexibility.

The question Angela was facing was no longer whether Jazz Winnipeg should evolve, but instead how deliberately and how boldly. The organization could not continue to absorb small annual losses and could not abandon the commitments that defined its role in Winnipeg's cultural landscape. Any meaningful change would impact programming, staffing, partnerships, and the relationship with the audience. Revenue decisions could not be separated from identity.

The central question that needs to be answered is **how can Jazz Winnipeg evolve without losing what made it special?** In answering this question Angela realized that there were several unresolved questions:

- How should accessibility be defined in an era where digital platforms and experiential expectations were reshaping how people engage with culture?
- What role should the festival play in relation to year-round programming and emerging forms of entertainment?
- How much risk – financial, organizational, and reputational – was Jazz Winnipeg prepared to accept in pursuit of long-term sustainability?
- Are there opportunities to support local artist development and grow Manitoba’s reputation as a jazz hotbed?

The path forward would not be determined by a single initiative or source of funding. It would have to align mission, operating model, and capacity around a shared understanding of what Jazz Winnipeg needed to be 5+ years from now. With limited resources but renewed momentum, Angela faced a narrowing window to choose between gradual adaptation and bold transformation. Whatever the path, the future of Jazz Winnipeg depended on decisions that could not be deferred. The challenge was to find a new arrangement – one that allowed Jazz Winnipeg to improvise without losing the melody that sustained it for decades.

Appendix A: Jazz Winnipeg Revenue Mix

Source	Percentage
Philanthropic Donations (Individual)	3%
Foundations	9%
Sponsorship	16%
Box Office	19%
Other Earned Income	23%
Government Sources*	30%
**Government grants expected to decline*	

Appendix B: Jazz Winnipeg – By the Numbers

